

Rethinking What You Think You Know: Early Childhood Special Educators' Critical Reflection on Their Practice.

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Abstract (120 words):

This qualitative meta-analysis explores how early childhood special educators critically reflect on their practice to support inclusive classrooms. Drawing from two preschool stories, the study examines how teachers confronted philosophical tensions and reconsidered familiar strategies to address the complex needs of children with disabilities. Grounded in Disability Studies in Education (DSE) and Disability Critical Race Theory (DisCrit), findings highlight how teachers engaged in deeper levels of self-reflection and interdisciplinary collaboration to rethink deficit-based assumptions and adapt their pedagogical approaches. Through reflective inquiry, teachers reimagined inclusive practices to create responsive, equitable learning environments. This study contributes to understanding inclusion as an evolving, multifaceted process that demands ongoing reflection, flexibility, and a commitment to honoring all children's identities and ways of being.

Objectives

Despite the increase in classrooms that profess to be inclusive, challenges to providing a genuinely inclusive educational experience for diverse learners remain unresolved (Guralnick & Bruder, 2016). When young children in inclusive early childhood classrooms present unique social and educational needs, teachers are required to rethink their beliefs and practices to find creative and flexible teaching strategies (Klefbeck & Holmqvist, 2023).

This study explores how teachers were encouraged to reconsider and expand their previous notions of effective teaching practices to address young children's complex and dynamic needs in daily classroom contexts. Through a meta-analysis of two diverse inclusive preschool case studies, we engaged in a re-examination of teacher inquiry data to learn more about teachers' perspectives on negotiating multiple approaches to inclusive practice. We looked deeply at the ways that teachers engaged in critical reflection on their own beliefs and practices and considered other disciplinary approaches as they strove to meet the needs of young children with disabilities. This study addressed the following research questions:

- 1) What inner conflicts do early childhood teachers experience when supporting the unique learning needs of young children with disabilities?
- 2) How do they reflect on their own beliefs and their previous teaching experiences as they address children's needs and strive to support an authentic inclusive environment?

Perspective/theoretical framework

Within the frameworks of Disability Studies in Education (DSE) and Disability Critical Race Theory (DisCrit), teachers are viewed as key agents in fostering inclusive classrooms that value diversity and ensure all students—regardless of ability—have equitable access to learning (Naraian, 2021; Rood, 2021). Beneke and colleagues (Beneke et al., 2019) attribute bias among educators to ableism—teachers' beliefs that disability is a characteristic that must be "fixed" to align with developmental norms. From DSE/DisCrit perspectives, teachers are called to engage in critical reflection to challenge deficit-oriented practices rooted in structural ableism, which

can result in the discrimination and marginalization of children with disabilities (Friedman et al., 2022; Love & Beneke 2021).

This study builds on this body of work by exploring moments when teachers' well-intended efforts to implement strength-based approaches lead to complex and challenging situations that require deeper levels of reflection. It seeks to capture how teachers engaged in reflective practice, stepping outside of their prior knowledge and experience to find ways of meeting the needs of young children with disabilities.

Methods

Two preschool stories, previously analyzed in separate case studies, were selected for this qualitative meta-analysis to explore tensions, often stemming from different philosophical perspectives in inclusive early childhood classrooms. Through a re-analysis of teacher interviews and reflections, we looked more deeply at teacher perspectives, illuminating their thoughts and ideas through their own voices.

Data sources

Classroom One was a private, state-supported school serving students who are Deaf/Hard of Hearing (D/HH) and hearing children. The class had a total of 12 preschoolers, 6 children who are D/HH and 6 hearing children, a general education teacher, Terry, a special education teacher, Jane, and an assistant teacher. The teachers had several years of experience working with children with disabilities but were relatively new to working with D/HH children. The program offers a unique inclusive environment prioritizing spoken language for participants. There is a Listening and Speaking Language (LSL) program in place, and the professionals in this classroom use typical learning activities to promote language development.

Classroom Two was a toddler room at a university-affiliated childcare center. Two head co-teachers, Anna and Eva, enacted a play-based, child-led, responsive/emergent curriculum. Anna was a certified early childhood teacher, and Eva was dually certified in early childhood/special education. There were 10 toddlers in their classroom ranging in age from 21-36 months. One 2-year-old boy, Rafael, was diagnosed with autism. The teachers described their classroom as a space where the children could be "*comfortable being who they are*" (Anna) and able to "*take ownership of their experiences and their roles in the classroom*" (Eva). They strove to create a community that allowed space for the children to "*try on new roles*" (Anna) and "*get to know who [they] could be/want to be*" (Eva).

Results

Although each setting was unique, similar issues arose regarding the challenges of working with different teaching approaches, and the need to rethink daily practice and reconceptualize learning expectations.

Realizing the need to rethink what they already know

Many special education teachers have been prepared to consider visual supports as a primary tool for teaching young children with and without disabilities. In Classroom One, however, teachers needed to reconsider this strong emphasis on visual supports to truly include D/HH children in a speaking environment. Tensions between professionals who embrace spoken language versus ASL in teaching children with hearing differences created some initial challenges in this setting.

This school embraced an auditory-first approach, focusing less on what children see and more on what they hear. When children with hearing impairments receive cochlear implants, they

need to go through a long process of learning how to understand the spoken language. This shift requires teachers to reconsider their teaching methods. In an effort “to help them have full access to the curriculum,” Terry stated that rather than focusing on the visuals, she had “to learn to listen and then listen to learn.” While visuals should not be eliminated completely, the program emphasized that they should be used as an additional reinforcement tool instead of a primary support to strengthen children’s listening skills.

The introduction of ABA into the play-based, emergent environment of Classroom Two created unanticipated tensions for the teachers as they tried to navigate their own roles as collaborators. Anna and Eva questioned the value in introducing too much structure into their interactions with Rafael. *I struggled with requiring Rafael to do things I didn’t make the others do (making him say “push me” on the swings or forcing him to say, “All done” at the table) (Anna).* They worried about taking away his freedom to explore on his own and make his own choices in play, which were core elements of their teaching philosophy. Eva reflected: *While I understood the intent behind it, I felt like much of it was disconnected from his actual experiences or unnecessary in the grand scheme.*

Changes in thinking that lead to creating a more inclusive community they got diagnosed with Autism then intensive intervention mostly ABA presented both challenges and rewards for teachers new to the teaching and learning environment started to in Classroom One. Despite initial feelings of discomfort about limiting visuals, over time, speak - hard to teachers began to recognize the benefits of encouraging students to rely on auditory input, learn ultimately giving D/HH children more “speaking power” in the classroom. They worked on retraining their approach, focusing less on what students see and more on what they hear.

It's like learning a different language because in special ed, everything you do is one way. And, I mean, obviously, different strategies and stuff, but it's like the visual. This kid needs a visual. Everything's so visual. So, to completely strip that away, it feels strange at first, but now, it's starting to feel a lot more natural.” (Jane)

ABA much of the experience was “disconnected from his experience” (teacher) he had to ask push me before being pushed or do all done

In Classroom 2, Rafael’s initial refusal/inability to respond to the teachers’ usual ways of inviting and supporting toddlers pushed them out of their comfort zones and forced them to find new strategies for working with him. As they opened their classroom to collaboration with EI specialists, they were pushed even further toward rethinking what it meant for Rafael to be “comfortable being who he is” and to be able to “get to know who he could be/want to be” as a member of the toddler community. By developing clearer communication and social skills in response to ABA therapy, Rafael was better understood by his teachers and peers and could respond more meaningfully to the toddler teachers’ less prescriptive ways of teaching.

Scholarly Significance

Findings from our study illustrate the dilemmas faced by early childhood professionals as they engage with children in inclusive classrooms whose needs are not adequately addressed by their usual teaching strategies. Although participating teachers were well-prepared to engage in what they believed was a strengths-based and anti-ableist approach to inclusion, they needed to unlearn/rethink what they believed were ‘best practices’. Teachers gained new insights through collaborating with professionals who held different beliefs about teaching and learning to empower children with complex and challenging needs to find their voices as members of the

classroom community. As they continue to expand their thinking about their practice in response to different kinds of learners, successful inclusive educators must learn to ‘*figure out how to better enact their most cherished ideals*’ (Danforth, 2017, p.18) in meeting the unique needs of their students. Understanding inclusion as interdisciplinary practice requires drawing on diverse educational ideologies, re-imagining old ideas to foster new ways of thinking, doing, and being.

Many studies (Lee & Alonzo, 2024; Park et al., 2021; Recchia & Lee; 2013) examine inclusive early childhood practices grounded in strength-based approaches. However, implementing these practices is not always straightforward. To truly embody anti-ableism in their teaching, sometimes the ‘best practice’ for an individual child requires teachers to engage in a deeper level of reflection, challenging their prior knowledge and stepping outside their comfort zones. This deeper level of reflection both honors children’s neurodiversity and advances ability justice. Ultimately, the journey towards implementing an anti-ableist approach is multi-dimensional and complex, requiring both straightforward solutions and, at times, practices that may not appear to align with anti-ableist practice, acknowledging that no single method can reach every child. There are many ways to create inclusive spaces where all children have opportunities for their voices to be heard.

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This presentation reflects the upcoming 2nd edition of our book:

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